‘At Cape Comorin, sitting in Mother Kumari’s temple, I hit upon a plan: we are so many sannyasins wandering about, and teaching the people metaphysics? It is all madness. Did not our Gurudeva once say, “An empty stomach is no good for religion?” That those poor people are leading a life of brutes is simply due to ignorance… Suppose some sannyasins, bent on doing good to others, go from village to village, disseminating education and seeking in various ways to better the condition of all down to the Chandala…can’t that bring forth good in time? … We, as a nation, have lost our individuality, and that is the cause of all mischief in India. We have to give back to the nation its lost individuality and *raise the masses*…’ Vivekananda wanted ‘to set in motion a machinery which will bring noblest ideas to the doorstep of even the poorest and the meanest’.

These ideas galvanised his followers, in a country that had long been inured to the tyranny and oppression faced by a majority of the people. And thus began a new epoch in his life. Nationalism—not just in the sense of overthrowing the foreign ruler, but in the sense of national reawakening—became a prominent theme in Vivekananda’s thought. He believed that a country’s future depended on its people, and his teachings focused on what today we might call human development. Our modern systems of governance have a lot to learn from his teachings. His assessment of the social problems of India was realistic, rather than theoretical. He connected with the common man to a degree that would be the envy of most modern politicians, largely owing to the fact that he wandered all over the country with a few followers and a begging bowl in his hand.

What bothered the Swami, even more than poverty itself, was the gulf between the rich and the poor, between the high-placed and the low-born, and further, the ugly sight of the strong regularly oppressing the weak. ‘This is our native land’, he often bemoaned, ‘where huts and palaces exist side-by-side.’ Such was the dichotomy of the times that it seemed inconceivable to him that India could have the unity and brotherhood which are preconditions for national greatness. Born, as it were, a ‘disunited mob’, we could not combine: in our unity would lie the fulfilment of our nationhood.